Loose Thread

By Percy Pham

EXT. TIMES SQUARE - BROADWAY - MIDNIGHT

LIAM and JOEL walked down Broadway. It was midnight, but somehow the street was still crowded. Billboards flashed ads; restaurants (both the McDonald's on every corner and some high-end places) were still packed.

LIAM (whispered to himself)
Damn... 2 AM?

JOEL turned to LIAM
What about it?

LIAM
Everything is packed. Thought everything was closed by now?

JOEL
Oh that?

He paused a bit and turned to the building next to him.

JOEL (CONT'D)
Maybe that's just the perks of having NYU and Columbia kids running around. Plus it's Saturday... or actually Sunday.

LIAM
Yeah, but like, it is 2 AM. Why did all of them decide to meet up like right now? Shouldn't they just... call it a day and sleep?

JOEL
Then why are you here? You are one of them too.

LIAM
Well, I missed my flight yesterday. The flight took off at 7:40, and I woke up at 7.

JOEL
So you decided to mind as well, do an all-nighter so you wouldn't miss this one.

LIAM
Smart right?

JOEL and LIAM stopped at the L train station.

JOEL was deep in thought, and then he looked at LIAM
When is your flight?

LIAM
7:40....

JOEL
Again? How are you going to kill the next 4 hours?

LIAM
Walking through the street, in a foreign city. Lots to explore.

The train slowly approached. LIAM hopped on first and tapped his Metro card. He casually sat in an empty seat, while JOEL stood next to him, holding onto a pole. It was bright and mostly empty, with the few passengers scattered around, deep in their own conversations.

INT. L TRAIN- MIDNIGHT
JOEL
So why are we on this?

LIAM
I can't tell. Maybe to find the reason why this city wants to keep me here for one more day.

They stared at the dark window. Instead of the city, the glass reflected the subway car behind them. A group of NYU students dressed for a night out, laughing loudly over the train's rattle, arguing about which afterparty to hit next.

LIAM, with a visible sadness on his face (CONT'D)
Do you believe in coincidence... faith... destiny? Or miracle?

JOEL
Depends. You missed your flight. Was that coincidence, or just bad luck?

LIAM
I would say... maybe?

JOEL
Maybe. Like it's all come down to whether something will happen tonight.

LIAM sighed
Nothing's going to happen.

JOEL confused
Then why didn't you go back to your friend's house and sleep? A little bit earlier than yesterday.

LIAM
Because I wanted to leave the door unlocked. Even if I know nobody's walking through it.

JOEL studies him for a second. He lets go of the pole, nudging LIAM over to take the aisle seat beside him.

LIAM
I mean, it definitely felt like it before.

JOEL
Well, let's see. You took a week off uni, spent two days losing a hackathon, broke your phone, and wandered around New York only to miss your flight. The only miracle here is that you get to spend one more day in this city.

LIAM
Yeah, but...

JOEL
But what?

The train squealed against the rails, coming to a sudden stop

CONDUCTOR (V.O.) (through crackling speaker)
Fourteenth Street. Eighth Avenue. Transfer to the A, C, and E trains.

LIAM
Wait... Get up!

The door chime rang out. LIAM jumped up, grabbed JOEL by the arm, and pulled him out just before the doors slammed shut behind them.

EXT. 14TH STREET - MEATPACKING DISTRICT - 2:45 AM
They rushed out onto the street. The clubs were letting out, but the sidewalks were still swarming. People were shouting over idling Ubers, couples huddled outside a pizza window, and groups laughing loudly after partying. LIAM and JOEL looked completely out of place compared to them.

JOEL
How about you? Do you?

LIAM
I wanted to, but don't know how to anymore.

JOEL
So you used to believe in it?

LIAM
I felt it before, though. Back in Seattle.

JOEL
With her?

LIAM
With her.

LIAM paused a bit

LIAM (CONT'D)
I think everyone does at some point. It's just too sad to think the world is really that bleak. Like, why would you choose not to believe something great is waiting for you, when that only makes you feel trapped?

JOEL
And yet you lost it?

LIAM
Well, not yet. I am still here waiting for a miracle, aren't I?

JOEL
So you believe that you will meet her again?

LIAM looked across the street at a couple laughing and kissing in line for food. A faint look of longing crossed his face before he looked away.

LIAM (CONT'D)
It felt planned. Like a setup, at first. But I fumbled it so hard. I was lost back then... Not that I have my life together now, but I was really lost. Four months of doing nothing, or doing something dumb, and we never saw each other again. Two days ago, I found out she moved to this city. But nothing happened on this trip.

JOEL
Is it really on you, though? Like entirely your fault, like you keep saying to yourself?

LIAM
It was just me. I hated when people blamed something else.

JOEL
So this whole extra day, you expected a miracle to happen again.

LIAM
No... no... Not expected. Hope maybe.

JOEL
So what do you do if nothing happened?

LIAM decided to sit down on the steps in front of Starbucks. JOEL followed his lead and sat to his left, both of them looking down the street. LIAM had this look; his eyes seemed to want something to happen, anything to prove him wrong, or maybe he was just too tired to care.

EXT. CLOSED STARBUCKS ' STEPS - 3 AM
LIAM
You know today is my birthday.

JOEL chuckled and patted Liam on the back.
Happy birthday.

LIAM chuckled softly.
No... that wasn't what I meant. I called my parents earlier. You know, the classic happy birthday song and the congrats.

JOEL
They were... really happy.

LIAM
And they asked if I had any plans for today. I said no. I got used to being on my own when I moved to America, but somehow it's just felt a lot heavier lately. When they asked what I wanted, I said nothing. My parents said that was fine, that I would figure it out later. You know, the logistics part of my birthday. I think I slipped up, though. I knew they saw through it. They went quiet for a second, just watching me try to string together a really messy sentence.

LIAM's eyes watered slightly, but he caught himself and quickly wiped it away with his hand.

LIAM (CONT'D)
They stayed on the phone for forty minutes trying to make me laugh, even though I wasn't crying. Reminding me of stupid things I did as a kid, talking about how far we'd come. Before we said goodbye, they told me I'd find something I loved soon. But I know that what I wanted is what they have with each other.

JOEL chuckled
So you want to marry her. I think that is a bit too early.

LIAM
Can you pass me water?

JOEL opened his backpack and gave LIAM his bottle of water. He took a sip and turned to the traffic light.

LIAM
Not exactly. My mom and dad usually just do their own thing. Dad stays in his room doing his art stuff, and Mom sits in the living room watching Netflix, making her little accessories. But they have this rule: always leave their doors open.

JOEL watched him quietly, listening.

LIAM (CONT'D)
She told me that whenever Dad is busy late at night, or away on a business trip, she gets really lonely. Even though they barely interact at night anyway, except when they finally go to sleep.

LIAM (CONT'D) capped the water bottle and gave it back to JOEL.
Here! Thank you.

JOEL put it in the backpack again
No worries.

LIAM (CONT'D)
And the Roomba... She really loves that thing. Trust me. Last summer when I was home, the Roomba died, and she completely panicked. We were supposed to watch a movie together, but she couldn't sit still. She told me she had to take it to the repair shop first and we'd have to finish the

movie later. And all because hearing it bump around the place makes her feel less alone when dad is away. It reminds her of him... Turning it on is his job.

A slight, sad smile touched LIAM's face, staring down at the pavement.

LIAM (CONT'D)
They really do love each other. They come up with weird little stuff to keep the loneliness when the others are away.

JOEL
So you want a second chance with her? To start everything from scratch? Maybe fall in love?

Liam looked down at his feet.

LIAM
I don't know. Maybe I just want us to have a chance to actually talk. I messed up last time, so we barely even know each other.

LIAM fiddled with the black hair tie wrapped around his wrist. (CONT'D)
But that doesn't really matter anymore.

LIAM took a deep breath.

LIAM (CONT'D)
The whole reason I want to believe in a higher power or god is because of her. I'm, what, ninety percent made peace with the idea that I'll never see her again. So now all I care about is knowing she's okay. That someone up there is making sure that she will be safe and... happy. And if that means burning my birthday wish and prayers tonight... asking them to look out for her instead of me... I'd do it in a heartbeat.

LIAM turned to his left. The street was quiet and lonely, and no one was there with him except for a few couples and strangers wandering past, heading home together, maybe just for tonight, maybe for good. He sat alone, his eyes locked on the weathered red-brick house across the road. His face emptied out. Silence settled in around him.